American missiles in Italy and Turkey. It was a reaction to Dean Rusk's proposal to force Khrushchev to cede control over his missiles in Cuba to the United Nations in exchange for a similar move by the United States with regard to its Jupiter missiles in Italy and Turkey. "There are only three places where nuclear missiles are present outside the territory of a nuclear power: Cuba, Turkey and Italy," argued Rusk. "This would be: Take them out of any country that is not a nuclear power," said Kennedy, reacting to Rusk's proposal. "Well, not 'take them out' at this phase. Just sit on them," responded Rusk, who simply wanted to make the Soviet missiles in Cuba nonoperational.

But Kennedy had hit on a bigger idea, that of trading Soviet missiles in Cuba for American ones in Italy and Turkey. "Why don't we go the whole way?" the president asked his reluctant secretary of state. Rusk was against referring to Italy and Turkey in the statement he was preparing for the United Nations. But Kennedy did not care about the statement: he was fascinated with his new idea. "This gives us an excuse to get them out of Turkey and Italy. As long as they are not connected with it [the American proposal to the UN], let's get them out of both places. We tried to get them out of that other place anyway."[8]

Later that day Kennedy asked Assistant Secretary of Defense Paul Nitze to look into the possibility of removing the missiles from both Italy and Turkey. He considered them worthless. The military knew that: with fifteen to twenty minutes required to prepare the missiles for launch, they were sitting ducks for a Soviet first strike—in fact, inviting it. Instead of deterring attack, they might well provoke it. But Nitze had political rather than military objections to the president's idea: the Europeans might perceive it as an American policy of removing the whole US nuclear arsenal from Europe. Kennedy assured the worried Nitze that removal of the missiles was his plan B. His plan A was to demand unilateral withdrawal of the Soviet missiles from Cuba.[9]

The Cuba-Turkey missile swap disappeared from the ExCom discussions. The State Department was opposed to it, and in the Department of Defense only the officers dealing with disarmament were in favor of it. But the swap became a subject of internal memos and, by October 25, it had spilled into the media. No less a figure than Walter Lippmann, who had